Competitive Battlecard

Who you are actually against, what they are better at, and where the ground favours us.

Status	Internal. Never leaves the building, never attaches to an email.
Sources	`docs/Gulf_Market_Analysis.md` §2, §3, §5. Refresh against it every quarter — competitor pricing moves.
Rule	Never disparage a competitor by name to a prospect. Everything here is for *your* preparation, so that you can be specific about us rather than negative about them.

The one-line map

THEY ARE CHOOSING	THE REAL QUESTION THEY ARE ASKING	OUR GROUND
CargoWise	"Is the price rise worth it?"	Cost, Arabic, implementation time
Logistaas	"Who is more MENA?"	Data ownership, enforcement depth, brand
CARGOES Runner (DP World)	"Should my landlord run my software?"	Independence
Nothing / spreadsheets	"Is this worth the disruption?"	The pilot, on their own data
A local dev shop	"Should we just build it?"	Two years of domain modelling they would repeat

CargoWise (WiseTech)

What they are. The incumbent. Deep, broad, global, and genuinely good at what it does. Nobody was ever fired for buying it.

Why the prospect is talking to you at all. WiseTech moved to "Value Pack" pricing in December 2025 and forwarders report cost increases of **20% to over 50%**. That landed on top of complaints that already existed: 50*k*–100k+ implementations, six to twelve months to go live, months of staff training, and ticket-based support that forwarders describe as *"if you call CargoWise, they tell you to watch a video."*

Their real advantages — concede these fast and precisely:

- Breadth. They do things we do not and will not.
- Global network effects — their eDocs and partner ecosystem.
- Nobody gets blamed for choosing them.

Where the ground favours us:

Cost shape	Our implementation is a fixed fee measured in weeks, not a six-figure project measured in quarters.

Arabic	Theirs is an English product with Arabic available. Ours is bilingual in the layout. Show, do not argue.
Time to value	Fifteen working days to a demo on their own data. Nobody else in this list offers that.
Support	A named person, not a ticket queue and a video library. This is the complaint they will volunteer if you ask.
Breadth as liability	A five-branch forwarder uses perhaps 15% of CargoWise and pays for the rest.

The question to ask, once, and then be quiet:

> "What did your renewal come in at this year, against last year?"

What not to do. Do not attack the product — it is better than ours at many things and the prospect knows it. Attack nothing. The price rise is doing the selling; your job is to be the credible alternative in the room when they decide to look.

If they say "we are already deep in CargoWise": believe them and go for coexistence rather than replacement — the customer portal, tracking and the Arabic quotation surface, alongside what they run; the read API and the outbound webhooks exist so what they run can be fed from ours. That is a real sale and it is how you get invited back when the next renewal lands.

Logistaas — the direct competitor, and the dangerous one

What they are. MENA-native, office in Amman, forwarders in 80+ countries. The closest thing to what we are selling, and further along on compliance.

What they have that we do not:

- e-invoicing across 30+ countries, including **Saudi ZATCA** and Jordan JoFatura
- direct connections to **Dubai Customs** and **Oman Customs**
- stated readiness for **UAE MPCI**
- an installed base and references we do not have

Do not pretend otherwise. If the prospect's buying reason is a compliance deadline that Logistaas meets today and we do not, we lose that deal and we should lose it quickly rather than expensively. Say so, keep the relationship, and come back when the roadmap item ships.

Where the ground favours us:

Their headline is our floor	"One platform, entities in different countries side by side" is their lead capability. Ours is enforced in database policies — 197 of them, across 82 tables — rather than in application code; it is structurally stronger, and it is demonstrable: ask for another branch's shipment and the row does not exist to the query.
Data ownership	We deploy per customer, into the customer's own database, in their region. Ask what happens to their data on their platform, and whether they can have it all back on any given Tuesday.
Whitelabel	Ours is a parameter — no colour literal or company name in any component. Theirs is a product with a logo slot. For a forwarder whose customers are their asset, that difference is worth money.

Arabic depth	Both credible here. Do not claim an advantage you cannot demonstrate in ten seconds on a phone.

The question to ask:

> "If you moved off them in three years, what would you be able to take with you?"

CARGOES Runner (DP World) — the structural threat

What they are. DP World markets it explicitly as *"an ERP solution for small and medium-sized freight forwarders to overcome technology barriers."* That is our exact segment, from a vendor that owns the ports, the terminal operating system, the customs relationships and the Digital Freight Alliance distribution channel.

We cannot out-distribute them and must not try. Bundling, port relationships and channel are unbeatable on our resources.

The only counter-position that works: independence.

> "It is good software and it will be cheap, because it is not really the product. Ask yourself who else sees your customer list, your lane volumes and your rate structures — and whether the company that owns the terminal your boxes sit in should be the company that holds them."

Say it once, calmly, and do not repeat it. Repeating it sounds frightened.

Where the ground favours us:

- **Neutrality.** We do not compete with our customers and never will.
- **Their data, physically theirs.** Their own database instance, their region, full export on demand.
- **Carrier and port agnosticism.** Nothing in the product prefers a terminal.

If the prospect is already a heavy DP World customer: this argument will not land and pushing it costs you the relationship. Compete on Arabic, brand and implementation speed instead, or walk.

Aramex Connect is the same structural dynamic — carrier-owned, launched in UAE and Saudi in November 2024. Same counter-position, same restraint.

The second tier

SynTrack (Synergia — UAE/KSA/Oman) and **Bridge Logistics Catalyst** (KSA/UAE) compete on localisation and price. Expect them in a competitive process rather than as the incumbent.

Where we win: enforcement depth, whitelabel, and the pilot. Where we lose: price alone. Do not chase a purely price-led deal to the bottom — a forwarder who buys on price alone will also churn on price alone.

Globally: GoFreight, Magaya, Freightoscope, Logitude, Scope by Riege, Softlink, Shipthis. They appear in every "CargoWise alternative" list, carry no GCC compliance story and no Arabic worth the name. If one of these is in the process, the deal is ours to lose on Arabic and local presence.

Doing nothing — the most common competitor

More deals are lost to *"not this year"* than to any vendor on this page.

What "nothing" looks like: spreadsheets, four mailboxes, a WhatsApp group, and thirty years of the operations manager's memory. It works. That is the problem — it works well enough that the cost of it is invisible.

Why the usual arguments fail. Efficiency arguments lose to inertia, because the person you are persuading is the one who will absorb the disruption. ROI models lose because they are built from your numbers, not theirs.

What works: the pilot. Fifteen days, their own data, fixed fee, credited in full. It converts an abstract decision into a concrete three-week experiment with a known cost and a visible end. From `docs/Qabandi_Pilot_15_Day.md` §1:

> "Nobody who has run freight out of five mailboxes for thirty-four years can picture what *the customer just looks it up* feels like until they see it happening to their own shipment reference."

The sentence that moves it:

> "You are not deciding whether to change your systems. You are deciding whether to spend three weeks finding out what changing them would look like — with the fee credited if you go ahead."

"We will just build it ourselves"

Usually the son, the nephew, or an IT manager with a contractor.

Do not be defensive; be specific about what they are quoting.

> "You can. Here is what you would be building, and I mean the parts that are not obvious.
>
> Money is `numeric(19,6)` end to end and rounds per currency at the line, because KWD carries three decimals — a global two-decimal rounding corrupts every Kuwaiti amount in the system, and you find that out at your first reconciliation. Every charge line stores its own FX rate and the moment it was taken, because otherwise a USD-priced quote invoiced in KWD does not reconcile six months later.
>
> Rate cards need temporal validity that makes two overlapping cards on one lane *unrepresentable*, not merely unlikely. Branch separation has to hold in the database, because the day it lives in application code is the day somebody forgets it in one query. The audit trail has to be un-editable by the administrator, or it is not an audit trail.
>
> Right-to-left cannot be retrofitted — the layout is either logical from the start or it is rebuilt.
>
> None of that is hard. All of it is a year of finding out, and you find it out from your own customers."

Then concede the real one: they will own it. That is a genuine advantage and pretending otherwise insults them. The counter is time-to-value and the fact that they get their own database and a full export anyway — so they own the data, which is the part that actually matters.

Objection handling

OBJECTION	WHAT IS REALLY BEING ASKED	ANSWER
"You are too small."	"Will you exist in three years?"	Concede immediately — it is true. Then: the deployment is their own database, the schema is documented, the export is complete and available any day, and there is a source-escrow conversation available on request. The risk is real and it is bounded. Never bluff scale.
"Who else uses it?"	"Who has been burned before me?"	Name Al-Qabandi *only with written permission*. Otherwise: "one Kuwaiti forwarder live, and I would rather you spoke to them than took my word — let me ask them." Then actually ask.
"What about Kuwait customs filing?"	Often a genuine requirement	Straight answer: we do not do it and we are not planning to. Access runs through a 25-year concession held by a joint venture in which a major regional logistics group is the majority shareholder, to 2030. They have no commercial reason to enable a competitor's vendor. We capture declaration references, status, duty and the SLA clock, estimate the duty from the tariff table, and generate the customs pack the broker files from. If direct filing is their buying reason, we are not the product.
"What about VAT?"	Usually Kuwait; sometimes GCC-wide	Kuwait has no VAT law and the government's own plan rules it out before 2028. The data model already carries tax treatment, rate and per-line taxability, so when it arrives it is configuration rather than a rebuild. For Saudi, ZATCA is on the roadmap and not shipped — the hand-off to an accredited provider is built as a plug, the mandated document and the provider are not.
"Can it read our email / WhatsApp?"	Often the real pain	Email, yes: an enquiry sent to a branch mailbox is read into a proposal the coordinator accepts or rejects, and a supplier's bill from a known partner is read into lines and matched against the job. WhatsApp, no — not in this release, and do not hint at a date.
"Does it track containers?"	Usually "will I still be phoning the line?"	The carrier connection is built for Maersk, Hapag-Lloyd and CMA CGM and runs on *their* carrier API credentials, not ours. Until they hold those, milestones are entered by hand. Say it before they ask whether it is live.
"Can it do [feature]?"	Testing whether you will bluff	If it is built, show it. If it is on the roadmap, say which release. If it is not planned, say so. Never answer a capability question with "yes, with some configuration."
"Send me a proposal."	Frequently a polite exit	"I will, and it will be one page. Before I write it — what would have to be true for you to sign it?"
"It is too expensive."	Almost never about the absolute number	Ask what they are comparing it to. If CargoWise: compare implementation totals, not licence lines. If nothing: the pilot fee is the answer, and it is credited.
"Our staff will never use it."	The operations manager is protecting their people	Take it seriously — they are usually right about their own team. Answer with Arabic, with the fact that the interface is task-shaped rather than form-shaped, and with the offer to put the ops manager in the pilot as the person whose vocabulary the milestones are named after. Involvement beats training.
"What happens if you disappear?"	Fair	Their own database, their own instance, full export, documented schema, escrow on request. Say the word *escrow* before they do.

Things never to say

NEVER	BECAUSE
"CargoWise is bloated / legacy / a rip-off"	The prospect chose it once. You are calling them foolish.
"We are cheaper" as the lead	It sets price as the axis, and someone is always cheaper.
"Yes, we can build that for you" — mid-demo	Every unpriced yes becomes a scope dispute in month two.
"That is coming soon"	Name a release or say it is not planned. "Soon" is how vendors lose the trust they are trying to build.
Anything about a named competitor's security or stability	Unprovable, actionable, and it makes you sound frightened.

Qualify out early

Walk away, politely and fast, when:

- **Direct Kuwait customs filing is the buying reason.** `MK-03` — no route in.
- **A dated compliance mandate we have not shipped is the buying reason.** Say when it ships, ask to be called then, and leave.
- **They want feature parity with CargoWise.** Breadth is their moat and our liability. This deal ends in a scope fight and an unhappy reference.
- **There is no executive sponsor.** An operations manager alone cannot buy a system of record, and the deal will die in month four having consumed a quarter.
- **They will not give you data for the pilot.** It is the cheapest possible test of whether they are serious, and a prospect who will not send a rate card will not sign.